

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

24 May 2016

To a National Spiritual Assembly

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

Further to our letter dated 11 November 2015, sent in response to your email letter of 21 September 2014 enquiring about the applicability of Bahá'í laws related to burial and wills, the Universal House of Justice has instructed us to convey the following.

Enclosed is a basic overview, recently approved by the House of Justice, of laws of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas that are not yet universally applied. This document also sets forth the universally binding laws related to burial of the dead (see IV.D.1.k).

The writing of a will is one of the laws in the Kitáb-i-Aqdas which is already binding on the friends (see paragraph 109). Furthermore, as you will know from your study of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas, Bahá'u'lláh has laid down detailed rules for the devolution of property in cases of intestacy—that is, when the individual dies without leaving a will. However, as the enclosed overview confirms, the laws of intestacy in the Kitáb-i-Aqdas are currently not universally applicable and are normally covered by civil laws (see IV.C.3.a–n).

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

LAWS OF THE KITÁB-I-AQDAS NOT YET UNIVERSALLY APPLIED

March 2016

After the universal application of the provisions of the Badí' calendar, the Universal House of Justice has provided the following basic overview of laws noted in the Synopsis and Codification of the Kitáb-i-Aqdas which are not at present universally binding upon the friends. The numbers of the sections are given for ease of reference. As the House of Justice has explained in the Introduction to The Kitáb-i-Aqdas: The Most Holy Book, “where Bahá'u'lláh has

given a law as between a man and a woman, it applies mutatis mutandis between a woman and a man unless the context makes this impossible.”

All the exhortations listed in section IV.D.3 are applicable universally at the present time insofar as it is possible for the friends to implement them; for example, the exhortation to teach one's children to chant the Holy Verses in the Mashriqu'l-Adhkár can be literally carried out only on a limited scale at the present time, but the friends should, nevertheless, teach their children the Holy Writings as far as possible.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]